

The Unintended Political Consequences of Expanding Police Authority: Evidence From London*

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Abstract

Policies expanding police discretionary authority are widespread and politically contested, yet their effects on police behaviour, institutional trust, and political preferences remain poorly understood. We study Britain’s 2014 Anti-Social Behaviour, Crime and Policing Act, which authorised local councils to implement Public Space Protection Orders (PSPOs), prohibiting broadly defined anti-social activities and expanding officer discretion in designated areas. Using the first comprehensive dataset on PSPO implementation across London census tracts (2016–2024), linked to crime records, stop-and-search data, and electoral outcomes, we exploit PSPOs’ staggered adoption to identify causal effects. These policies increase unproductive police stop-and-search activity, disproportionately targeting non-white residents. Reported anti-social behaviour and other crimes remain unaffected. These findings suggest that vaguely defined discretionary enforcement tools can generate racially unequal policing without delivering the public order benefits that justify their adoption.

Keywords: Police; Anti-social behaviour; Stop-and-search; Political backlash; Local governance

JEL Codes: K42, D72, J15

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1 Introduction

In recent decades, many governments have expanded the discretionary powers of their police forces as a comparatively low-cost strategy for managing public order and safety. Instead of increasing police numbers—a process that is typically slow, administratively complex, and politically fraught—authorities have opted to grant police broader autonomy in identifying, addressing, and sanctioning behaviours deemed disruptive. This shift is visible across multiple jurisdictions, reflected in trends such as the militarisation of local police units, the introduction of suspicion-less stop-and-search powers, and the criminalisation of formerly tolerated forms of passive resistance (White House, 2025; UK Home Office, 2023; Italian Council of Ministers, 2025). Although such measures promise institutional flexibility and administrative efficiency, they also recalibrate the balance between state authority and individual rights. Discretion has always been central to policing (Finnane, 1990), but its expansion raises distinct concerns when powers are broadly framed or lack clear procedural constraints (Yao, 2023). Under these conditions, traditional mechanisms of oversight and accountability may not scale proportionally to the authority delegated to frontline officers, creating uncertainty about how these powers are applied in practice and what outcomes they generate. Despite renewed policy interest and ongoing debates over whether enhanced discretion improves public safety without infringing civil liberties (Owens, 2020), empirical evidence on the broader societal and economic consequences of these reforms remains limited.

A central rationale behind these expansions draws on the “broken windows hypothesis” (Kelling and Wilson, 1982), which posits that visible signs of disorder left unaddressed signal the absence of social control and invite escalation to more serious offending (Burney, 2009). Under this logic, criminalising pre-criminal and sub-criminal conduct—such as loitering, public gatherings, or street drinking—serves a dual purpose: it addresses neighbourhood nuisance directly, and it functions as an investigative gateway through which officer-citizen encounters initiated for minor infractions can surface evidence of more serious criminal activity (Archer, 2023; Laniyonu, 2019). Anti-social behaviour legislation has accordingly been shaped by this dual ambition, treating the enforcement of low-level disorder not merely as an end in itself but as a proactive strategy for detecting and deterring more serious crime. Whether this rationale translates into measurable crime-reduction benefits, and who bears the costs of its unintended consequences, remains empirically contested.

To address this gap, in this paper we investigate how expanding police discretionary power affects police conduct. We then study the subsequent effects on individuals’ political engagement. Our empirical setting exploits the introduction of Public Space Protection Orders (PSPOs) in London beginning in 2016. Created under the 2014 legislation in England and Wales, PSPOs empower local councils to prohibit specific behaviours—sometimes defined in very broad terms, such as “using foul and abusive language”,¹ “reckless be-

¹Source: [ITV News](#), 2nd March 2016.

haviour”, or “gathering in a group”²—classified as antisocial but not previously deemed criminal. Crucially, PSPOs do not expand police stop-and-search powers and do not mandate additional officer deployment, but simply increase the pool of anti-social behaviour crimes. By expanding the scope of police discretion in affected areas, we show that these Orders lowered the threshold for officer suspicion and lead to unintended significant changes in policing practices unrelated to mere anti-social behaviours detection. We then examine how residents’ electoral behaviour shifted following PSPO adoption, focusing on party-related political preferences.

To do so, we assemble a novel dataset that draws on multiple sources. First, we hand-collect the universe of PSPOs issued in the Greater London Area from 2016 to 2024, compiling detailed information on their timing, content, and geographic coverage. We retrieve the full text and associated map of each implemented Order and code their boundaries at the census-tract level.³ By 2024, 87% of London had been subject to at least one PSPO, with the majority implemented between 2017 and 2018. Notably, around 20% of treated areas were covered by Orders with broad or vaguely specified targets, often addressing activities such as assembling, loitering, or simply gathering in groups. Next, we construct a census-tract-by-semester panel from 2016 to 2024 by merging the PSPO dataset with administrative data on criminal incidents and police stop-and-searches obtained from the UK Police repositories. Crime records report the type, location, and date of each incident, while stop-and-search data include the demographic characteristics of stopped individuals and the ethnicity of the officer involved. To measure changes in political responses to PSPOs, we analyse party-level vote shares in council elections from 2014, 2018, and 2022. We exploit the staggered introduction of PSPOs at the census-tract level to causally identify the policy’s effect, estimating event-study models using recent advances in the difference-in-differences literature that allow for variation in treatment timing across units (Sun and Abraham, 2021).

Following the implementation of the PSPO, we find no change in reported incidents of anti-social behaviour, the primary target of the policy. This null effect may reflect either the limited effectiveness of the policy or a deterrence mechanism: as the set of behaviours classified as anti-social increased, local residents may have become more aware of the risk of sanction and refrained from engaging in such behaviour. On police behaviour unrelated to anti-social behaviour crime detection, we document a sharp increase in stop-and-search activity in treated areas, amounting to approximately 7 additional stops per census tract per semester, roughly one year after PSPO adoption. Critically, the composition of search outcomes shifts toward unproductive stops: treated areas exhibit a rise in the number of stops and searches ending with no further action, while officer-detected crimes remain unchanged. Moreover, this increase is concentrated almost entirely among non-white residents: a triple-difference design reveals a differential effect of 1.363

²Source: [The Guardian](#), 6th December 2024.

³Census tracts correspond to Lower Super Output Areas (LSOAs) under the 2011 UK Census classification; London contains approximately 4,800 LSOAs.

additional searches per 1,000 inhabitants per semester for non-white relative to white individuals, consistent with minority status acting as a proxy for suspicion when the *de facto* costs of initiating stops are reduced by PSPO designations (Knowles, Persico and Todd, 2001a). Taken together, these patterns are consistent with pretextual enforcement: PSPOs are likely to lower the threshold for officer-citizen encounters without generating the investigative or deterrent benefits used to justify them. Finally, we provide suggestive evidence about the policy’s political costs. Treated electoral wards experience a shift in political support away from the main architect parties of the legislation at the national level, towards UKIP and the Labour Party, broadly suggesting that the policy generated a broad-based backlash among affected communities.

This paper speaks to three strands of the literature. First, it contributes to the growing body of research studying the effects of policing policies on crime (Draca, Machin and Witt, 2011; Facchetti, 2024; Mastrobuoni, 2019). While this literature has widely discussed the effects of changes in the presence of police officers on crime, it has paid limited attention to the quality and nature of policing practices. We shift the focus onto the expansion of discretionary police power, providing causal evidence on how granting officers broader enforcement authority shapes crime outcomes and police behaviour beyond what deployment alone can explain.

Second, this paper adds to the literature on the drivers of police behaviour and discrimination, expanding the analysis on how individual officer characteristics, implicit bias, and local institutional contexts shape enforcement patterns (Barilari and Zambiasi, 2025; Hoekstra and Sloan, 2022; Knowles, Persico and Todd, 2001a; LeRoy, 2024; Mastrorocco and Ornaghi, 2025). We complement these contributions by showing that the criminalisation of minor and generically defined behaviours creates structural conditions for discriminatory enforcement, expanding police authority in ways that leave substantial room for discretion. Crucially, we show that this discretion is systematically exercised along racial lines, with non-white residents bearing a disproportionate share of increased enforcement activity, consistent with statistical and taste-based discrimination mechanisms documented in this literature.

Third, our paper contributes to the literature investigating the relationship between policing, political trust, and electoral outcomes. Prior research has predominantly focused on the political consequences of violent police behaviour, documenting how the use of force and the occurrence of high-profile incidents of police violence erode institutional trust and reshape civic engagement (Morris and Shoub, 2024; Tyler, Fagan and Geller, 2014; Weaver and Lerman, 2010). We broaden the scope of this literature by suggesting that the political costs of policing are not confined to extreme incidents, but are also produced by the everyday, structural misuse of discretionary power, offering new preliminary insights into how routine enforcement practices shape political behaviour in affected communities. Even non-violent expansions of police discretionary authority, operating through the systematic over-policing of minor and vaguely defined offences, might be sufficient to erode institutional trust and generate measurable electoral backlash.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 discusses the institutional background,

Section 3 describes the conceptual framework, while Section 4 introduces the data. Section 5 illustrates the empirical strategy, Sections 6 and 7 discuss the main results and robustness checks, and Section 8 highlights our main conclusions.

2 Institutional Context

2.1 Public Spaces Protection Orders

The Crime and Disorder Act 1998 introduced the first general statutory definition of anti-social behaviour (ASB) in England and Wales: conduct that “*caused or was likely to cause harassment, alarm or distress to persons not of the same household*” (Home Office, 1998).⁴ Enforcement was individual-based: Anti-Social Behaviour Orders (ASBOs) were civil orders imposed by a court, to the criminal standard of proof, on named individuals, and their breach was a criminal offence punishable by up to five years’ imprisonment.

The Anti-social Behaviour, Crime and Policing Act 2014, passed by the Conservative–Liberal Democrat coalition with little political opposition (Brown, 2017), extended ASB regulation from *individuals* to *places*. Its key innovation, the Public Spaces Protection Order (PSPO), regulates conduct within a designated geographical area rather than the conduct of a named individual: an Order binds anyone present in the area, irrespective of prior behaviour.⁵ This extension came with two further shifts.

First, PSPOs are issued administratively by local councils, with no intervention by central government or the judiciary (Archer, 2023).⁶ The council identifies activities that have a persistent “*detrimental effect on the quality of life of those in the locality*”, i.e., conduct that would not otherwise constitute a criminal offence, ranging from dog fouling, begging, and littering to more ambiguously defined activities such as street noise, public gatherings, or speaking in public spaces. Then, the council defines precisely the geographical area that the Order covers.⁷ Consultation with local policing bodies and community representatives is mandatory before adoption, while publicity is left to the council’s discretion.⁸ Once adopted, Orders last three years and can be renewed for further three-year periods without limit or supporting evidence.

Second, sanctions are lighter than under the ASBO regime but applicable at scale. Breach of a PSPO is a summary offence: enforcement officers (police officers, community support officers, or council and private security staff) may issue a Fixed Penalty Notice of £100 on the spot, which discharges liability, while

⁴The term had circulated in policy debate since the early 1990s and had appeared in housing legislation (Housing Act 1996), but the 1998 Act, introduced by the first Blair government in line with its *tough on crime* agenda and influenced by “broken windows” theory (Kelling and Wilson, 1982), provided the first general legal definition. The Act also created equivalent orders in Scotland, while Northern Ireland followed in 2004.

⁵PSPOs apply in England and Wales only. The ASBO itself was replaced by two person-based instruments, civil injunctions and Criminal Behaviour Orders; the PSPO instead succeeded three narrower place-based tools regulating alcohol consumption (Designated Public Place Orders), dog control (Dog Control Orders), and access to public rights of way (gating orders).

⁶What constitutes the affected population, and what evidence is required to justify an Order, is entirely at the discretion of the local authority. In 2018, the Home Office (2018) released non-binding guidance encouraging councils to formulate balanced Orders that do not target vulnerable populations.

⁷Figure A1 reports an extracted sample from a PSPO implemented by the London Borough of Barking and Dagenham.

⁸Figure A2 shows some examples advertising the adoption and application of PSPOs across the UK.

non-payment leads to prosecution and a fine of up to £1,000 (ss. 67-68). The Act creates no bespoke arrest power and no custodial sanction for breach. This street-level enforcement structure grants officers considerable discretion in determining both whether a prohibited behaviour is occurring and which response is proportionate, with no requirement to document the grounds for escalation (Archer, 2023).

2.2 PSPOs and stop-and-search powers

In London, stop and search is exercised by Metropolitan Police Service (MPS) officers under two statutory frameworks. The Police and Criminal Evidence Act (PACE) 1984 authorizes a search where an officer has reasonable suspicion that an individual carries weapons, drugs, firearms, or objects capable of causing criminal damage (Home Office, 1984; Bridges, 2015). Section 60 of the Criminal Justice and Public Order Act 1994 allows searches without suspicion, but only in areas and time windows (24 to 48 hours) pre-authorized by a senior officer in anticipation of serious violence (Home Office, 1994).⁹ For the overwhelming majority of searches under PACE, reasonable suspicion is assessed by the individual officer on the spot, with no prior authorization.

Relative to these powers, a PSPO is a minimal mandate. It assigns officers one narrow, fully specified enforcement task (warn, issue a £100 Fixed Penalty Notice, and prosecute on non-payment; see Section 2.1) and attaches an official designation to the area in which that task applies. It grants nothing else: the 2014 Act does not amend PACE or Section 60, creates no new search powers, and does not mandate additional police presence or resources in designated areas (UK Home Office, 2014).¹⁰ This implies that if officers applied these rules mechanically, PSPO designation would leave stop-and-search activity unchanged.

Any response of searches to designation therefore reflects a spillover of a new enforcement mandate onto a legally unrelated, high-discretion margin. This is the mirror image of Adda, McConnell and Rasul (2014), who show that removing an enforcement task, the depenalization of cannabis possession, reallocates police effort across offense margins. This spillover can operate through two channels, both within existing law.

The first is *contact*: discharging the mandate requires officers to approach, question, and warn individuals engaging in prohibited conduct, and each police-initiated encounter is an occasion in which the reasonable suspicion PACE requires can be formed. The second is *labelling*: MPS officers are trained to analyse ASB spatially through the SARA/VOLT framework, in which the designation of a problem area is a primary analytical input (Police, 2026a). A PSPO officially certifies an area as problematic, and can thereby lower the threshold at which conduct observed within it is read as suspicious, for anyone present and whether or not they engage in conduct the Order prohibits. The scope for the labelling channel is amplified by the breadth of many Orders: prohibitions on loosely defined conduct such as noise, loitering, or gathering

⁹PACE searches account for 97.2% of stop and searches in our sample, Section 60 searches for the remaining 2.8%. MPS policy commits officers to using these powers “*fairly and effectively*”, in compliance with the Equality Act 2010 and Article 14 of the Human Rights Act 1998 (Metropolitan Police Service, 2020).

¹⁰Internal MPS training materials confirm that responses to ASB follow a tiered escalation protocol in which stop and search plays no role (Police, 2026b).

in groups leave wide space to individual judgement (Livingston, 1997), and existing qualitative evidence indicates that PSPO enforcement falls disproportionately on visible and vulnerable groups (Brown, 2017; Archer, 2023; Heap and Dickinson, 2018).

Neither channel changes the legal powers themselves for enforcement officers. Both change the inputs to the officer’s discretionary judgement. The two channels also carry distinct empirical fingerprints: contact operates only through individuals engaged in conduct an Order prohibits, whereas labelling extends to all users of the designated space. We exploit this distinction below by comparing Orders whose targeted conduct does and does not generate contact with the population exposed to stop and search.

3 Conceptual Framework

The effects of PSPOs on anti-social behaviour and police conduct are *ex ante* uncertain, depending on how the expansion of police authority affects localised criminal conduct and whether it triggers unintended consequences through changes in police discretion.

As mentioned in Section 2, PSPOs are not intended to expand police powers of any type, and do not mandate additional police deployment in the treated area. Instead, PSPO legislation criminalises specific anti-social behaviour in a designated area, where individuals weigh the expected benefits of committing ASB against the probability of detection and the severity of sanctions. A PSPO may raise the perceived probability of sanctions being detected for ASBs within the designated area, thereby reducing the net benefit of committing anti-social behaviour. Under a deterrence mechanism, reported ASB incidents may rise in the short run, as officers actively enforce the new rules and incidents that would previously go unrecorded are now formally logged, before falling in the long run as individuals internalise the new constraints, while other policing-related activities such as stop-and-search and officer-detected crimes remain unaffected. Given that the geographic scope of PSPOs is limited, enforcement within treated areas may simply push anti-social behaviour into neighbouring areas rather than eliminating it. The spatial equilibrium literature suggests that offenders re-optimize over locations when the cost of offending in one area rises, making the net social effect of place-based interventions ambiguous (Chalfin and McCrary, 2018; Weisburd et al., 2006). This would imply a reduction of ASB in the treated area and a recorded increase of ASB in neighbouring ones, with other policing activities and officer-detected crimes unchanged.

It is also possible that the introduction of PSPOs creates the conditions for additional encounters between police officers and citizens, potentially lowering the legal threshold required to initiate other powers, including stop and search. If officers use this expanded authority and lower their suspicion threshold productively, we should both observe an increase in the number of stop and search which led to arrests, warnings, or sanctions, and higher detection rates: weapons, drugs, and public order offences, collectively officer-detected crimes (ODCs), which should rise alongside search volumes. A growing empirical literature finds that targeted, intelligence-led policing of this kind can reduce crime (Ratcliffe et al., 2011; Di Tella and Schargrodsky, 2004).

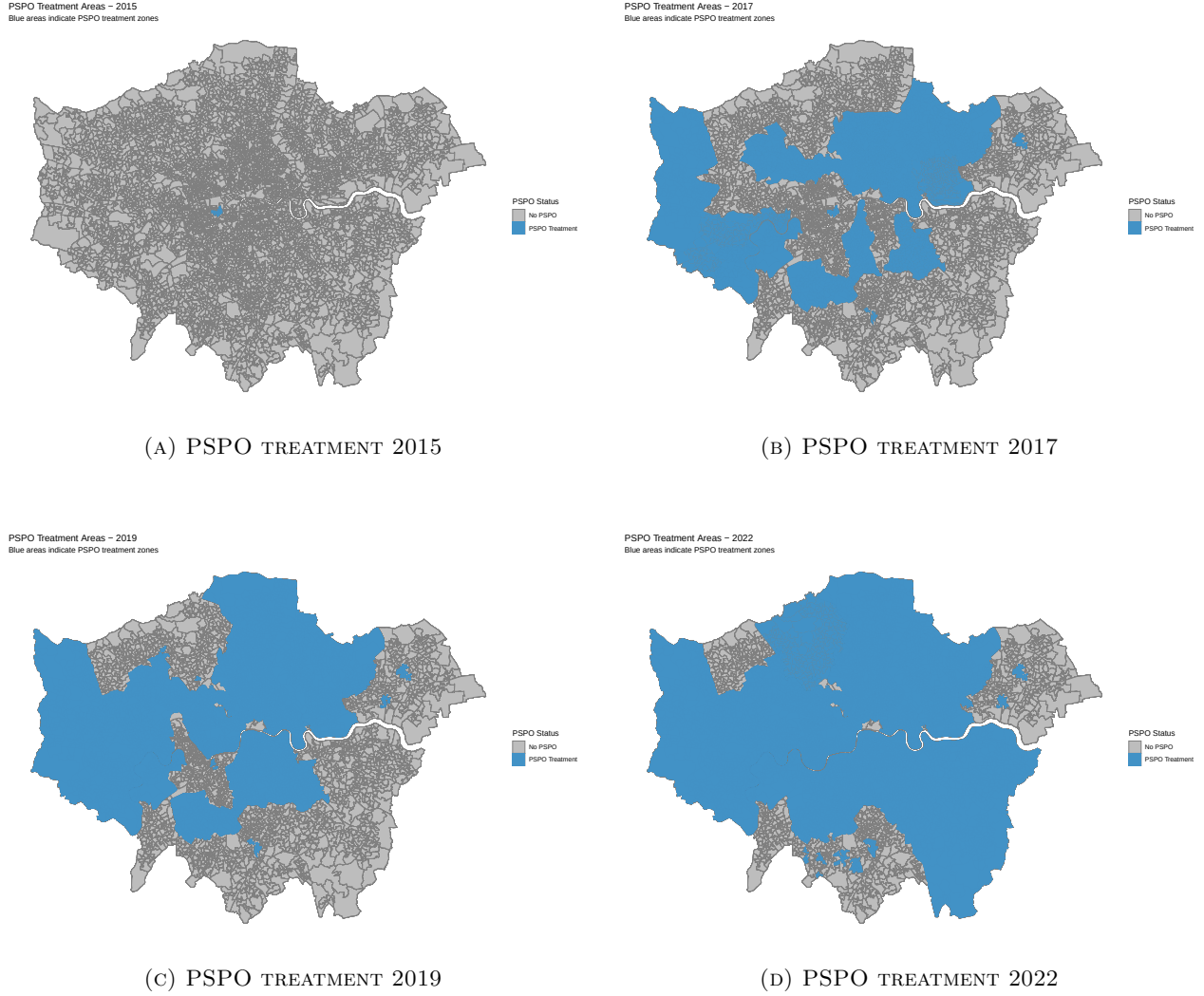
Alternatively, officers may engage in pretextual policing in PSPO-designated zones, *de facto* expanding not only the legal threshold for suspicion but also the discretionary space within which stop and search occur. Following Knowles, Persico and Todd (2001a), if PSPO designation lowers the *de facto* cost of initiating a stop, officers may optimise over stop volume rather than productive outcomes.

4 Data

Public Space Protection Order (PSPO) Data. To study the effects of localized expansions in police authority, we constructed a novel database of every PSPO in force in the Greater London Area between 2014 and 2024. The 2014 Act requires each local authority to publish the written order together with its accompanying map, but it does not prescribe a format and no central repository, so orders exist only as individual documents scattered across the website of each authority. We therefore built the database by extracting the text of every order published by a GLA local authority and recover, for each, the area designated, the conduct prohibited, and the date of formulation and of any subsequent extension or renewal.

Each order provides a map of the designated PSPO, which we digitize and then intersect the polygons with 2011 census tract boundaries, which are standardized geographic units typically containing 400–1,200 households and 1,000–3,000 residents. This exercise yields 94 orders, covering 87% of the Greater London Area by 2024, each matched to the census blocks it designates. Figure 1 shows the staggered implementation in the GLA. The order further provides information on the type of prohibition. As shown in Figure A4, these orders range from prohibiting alcohol consumption to dog control, and they are not mutually exclusive. Most of these areas are covered by several orders, and most commonly include prohibitions on alcohol, drugs, smoking consumption, and begging or loitering.

FIGURE 1: PSPO TREATMENT STATUS ACROSS YEARS



4.1 Outcomes

Crime Data. We collect data on recorded crime incidents from the Metropolitan Police database between January 2010 and October 2024.¹¹ We collect data on anti-social behavior crimes, drugs, weapons, and public order offences. The dataset is available at the monthly level which we aggregate to semesters (every six months) and map them to the 2011 census tracts.¹²

¹¹We exclude from our sample the data released by the City of London Police for two main reasons: first, crime records without a specific location recorded are usually attributed to the CoL police by MPS (Facchetti, 2025). Second, restricting the sample to a single police force ensures that all observations are subject to the same institutional recording practices, discretionary standards, and organizational policies throughout the sample period.

¹²We account for changes in LSOA boundaries between the 2011 and 2021 censuses by computing weights capturing how much of each 2021 LSOA falls in the region and rescale crime and stop-and-search counts accordingly. While we cannot observe the exact location of incidents within an LSOA, this approach mitigates the concern that apparent changes in crime or policing intensity reflect boundary redrawings rather than real shifts in activity. Under the assumption of homogeneity within each source zone (Goodchild and Siu-Ngan Lam, 1980), the rescaled counts provide an unbiased mapping to the 2011 geography.

Stop-and-Search Data. Along with crime data, we collect data on stop-and-search patterns from the MPS.¹³ The database contains almost 1.5 million of people or vehicles searched from June 2016 to October 2024, for which we know the place and the time of the search, the age range of the person searched, and the gender and ethnicity of the person searched. All stop and search records are mapped to their 2011 census tracts, for which we follow the same procedure adopted with crime records (Goodchild and Siu-Ngan Lam, 1980). Figure A5 shows the localized variation of the number of people stopped and searched across the full period. On average, 2 people get searched every month per census tract. We also have information about the last investigation outcome of each report and whether the search required the removal of more than just outer clothing. Figure A6 shows some descriptive statistics by the type of investigation outcome across years. Interestingly, we notice a clear decrease in the share of stop-and-searches ended with a warning, and an increase in the share of stop-and-searches with a local resolution achieved. For the purpose of our analysis, we aggregate the searches ending with no further actions and those ending with any further action to track different effects on searches’ outcomes.

Electoral Data. Next we collect data on council-level elections for each electoral ward in the GLA for the years between 2002 and 2022. The data are obtained from London Datastore (2024) and report the total number of votes, party-level and candidate-level number of votes for each electoral ward.¹⁴ For the purpose of our analysis, we collect information on the share of the votes cast for each party and turnout. Figure A7 shows the trends in electoral outcomes. The distribution of vote shares remains relatively stable across election cycles, with Labour and Conservative parties accounting for the largest shares.

4.2 Other Datasets

Police Stations and Officers Data. Following Facchetti (2025), we use data about the universe of MPS police stations to run several robustness checks on the interaction between the timing of PSPOs implementations and the effect of austerity cuts on the MPS budget. We download the data from the MPS archive of FOI requests, where police officers provide data requested by citizens online. We access information about the location of police stations, the date of their closure, whether a specific station remained open, and the number of police officers working for each MPS’ Basic Command Unit (BCU). We compute the time-varying distance from each census block to each open police station. Figure A8 shows the spatial distribution of police stations and the average number of operating police officers for treated and never-treated LSOAs.

House Prices Data. We collect data on LSOA-level housing prices in England and Wales from 2010 to 2020 from the LSE-Real Estate Economics and Finance (REEF). Following Ahlfeldt, Carozzi and Makovsky (2021), we create a pooled cross-section data on housing transaction with Energy Performance Certificate (EPC) data and use both parametric and non-parametric estimation to produce balanced panel price series.

¹³We follow the same practice employed for crime records, and we exclude from our sample the City of London.

¹⁴Wards represent the basic electoral units within London boroughs, with each ward typically electing two or three councilors representative of the residents in local governance decisions.

Therefore, the computed index ensures that housing prices are adjusted for specific features of individual houses. We use the housing prices as a proxy to test whether our results remain robust to any neighborhood gentrification which could attract more police attention or change demographic composition.

Other Data. We employ publicly available information from the 2011 and 2021 UK Census Data. We combine information on demographic characteristics, such as population density, age distribution, ethnicity, educational, and labor market trends. We employ this information as a part of our analysis to control for baseline demographic characteristics.

The designation of where to implement a PSPO and its timing are non-random by nature. Panel A of Table 1 shows that treated census blocks are considerably denser, have higher housing prices, and have a higher non-white population than never-treated blocks. Panel B shows that treated blocks display substantially higher baseline levels of crime: 58% more anti-social behavior, 46% more officer-detected crime (drug, weapons and public-order offenses), and 90% more stop and searches per 1,000 residents than areas never-treated. Panel C shows that treated wards are also politically distinct, leaning more toward Labor party and away from the Conservatives..

Although PSPOs' designation is not random, our identification strategy does not require similarity in levels. It only assumes that, absent the PSPO, treated and control census blocks would have followed parallel trends in policing and crime outcomes. Figure A9 shows that the never-treated and treated units followed similar trends before any PSPO was implemented, and we employ event studies to support this assumption in Section 5.

TABLE 1: DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS

	Treatment status		Adoption timing	
	Never	Treated	Later	Early
<i>Panel A: Baseline Characteristics</i>				
Housing price index (2014)	3,800 (1,414)	6,066 (3,215)	5,948 (3,725)	6,110 (2,999)
Population density per sq km	6,110 (3,640)	10,111 (6,231)	9,103 (5,847)	10,491 (6,329)
Share of non-white residents	0.281 (0.171)	0.410 (0.203)	0.398 (0.210)	0.414 (0.200)
Unemployment share	0.067 (0.032)	0.075 (0.034)	0.072 (0.031)	0.077 (0.035)
Share of over-65 residents	0.141 (0.052)	0.108 (0.048)	0.117 (0.046)	0.105 (0.048)
Log distance to closest open police station	7.231 (0.626)	6.945 (0.655)	7.020 (0.634)	6.916 (0.660)
Police strength (2015)	1.163 (0.940)	0.975 (0.672)	1.101 (0.717)	0.927 (0.648)
PCSOs per borough (2015)	4.695 (2.783)	4.431 (2.666)	4.414 (2.767)	4.438 (2.626)
<i>Panel B: Crime, Stop & Search per 1,000 residents</i>				
Anti-social behaviour	9.720 (9.296)	15.395 (17.042)	14.485 (13.885)	15.739 (18.078)
Officer-detected crime	4.015 (5.065)	5.880 (8.396)	5.545 (6.373)	6.006 (9.040)
S&S	5.202 (9.318)	9.873 (22.323)	8.661 (17.614)	10.330 (23.843)
S&S: Productive	1.635 (2.930)	2.741 (6.077)	2.413 (4.446)	2.865 (6.583)
S&S: Unproductive	3.567 (6.748)	7.131 (16.651)	6.248 (13.591)	7.464 (17.657)
S&S: White	3.574 (6.629)	6.257 (15.258)	6.288 (16.291)	6.245 (14.850)
S&S: Non-White	6.709 (12.759)	11.447 (28.770)	9.513 (21.032)	12.177 (31.164)
<i>Panel C: Electoral Outcomes</i>				
Conservative voteshare	0.364 (0.156)	0.286 (0.184)	0.362 (0.193)	0.256 (0.171)
Labour voteshare	0.318 (0.184)	0.395 (0.181)	0.351 (0.181)	0.413 (0.178)
Lib Dem voteshare	0.148 (0.154)	0.163 (0.133)	0.157 (0.119)	0.166 (0.139)
UKIP/Reform voteshare	0.047 (0.085)	0.021 (0.056)	0.031 (0.070)	0.017 (0.049)
Turnout	0.430 (0.120)	0.402 (0.116)	0.402 (0.119)	0.402 (0.115)

Notes: The table reports means with standard deviations in parentheses. Columns compare never-treated and treated units, and, among the treated, later- and early-adopting units. Panel A reports baseline LSOA characteristics; Panel B reports crime and stop-and-search outcomes per 1,000 residents. Panel C reports ward election outcomes. Sources: police.uk 2016–2024, London Datastore, UK Census 2011 and 2021, and the LSE-REEF house-price index.

5 Empirical Strategy

Our identification strategy exploits the staggered adoption of Public Spaces Protection Orders across London to recover the causal effect of PSPOs on crime, stop and search, electoral outcomes, and the mechanisms behind them. We define treated units as those whose centroid falls within a PSPO area, and compare them against never- and not-yet-treated units. Of the units in our sample, 4,197 census blocks are ever treated and 637 are never treated. More formally, following [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) we estimate the following model:

$$Y_{ubt} = \sum_{\substack{k=-K \\ k \neq -1}}^K \beta_k \text{PSPO}_{ut}^k + \alpha_u + \delta_t + \mu_{bt} + \varepsilon_{ubt} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{ubt} is the outcome for unit u , in borough b , observed in semester t . The unit of analysis is the census block (LSOA) for crime, stop-and-search, and search-composition outcomes, and the electoral ward for political outcomes. The indicators PSPO_{ut}^k equal one when unit u is k semesters from PSPO adoption, with the semester before adoption ($k = -1$) omitted as the reference. β_k trace the dynamic response of

the outcome around adoption.¹⁵ We include unit fixed effects α_u , semester fixed effects δ_t , and borough-by-semester fixed effects μ_{bt} , and standard errors are clustered at the unit level.

The borough-by-semester fixed effects are central to identification: rather than conditioning on baseline demographics, they let the level of crime and policing evolve flexibly and differentially across boroughs within each semester, so that treated units are compared only to other units in the same borough at the same date. Identification then rests on the parallel-trends assumption that, absent adoption, treated and comparison units within the same borough would have followed similar trajectories. This is plausible in our setting because PSPOs are adopted in response to localised, discretionary council decisions rather than to prior trends in the outcomes we study.

For electoral outcomes, Equation (1) is estimated at the ward level with t indexing election years; because adoption is overwhelmingly between-borough in this dimension, the fixed effects collapse to ward and election-year and standard errors are clustered at the borough level.

6 Main Results

6.1 Intended Effects: Deterrence and Displacement

We begin by investigating whether PSPOs achieved their intended purpose of reducing localized anti-social behavior crimes (ASB). Column (1) of Table 2 presents estimates of the effect of PSPOs on recorded ASB incidents per 1,000 inhabitants and provides no evidence that PSPOs reduced reported anti-social behavior. Figure 2 shows that pre-treatment coefficients are small and centered on zero, supporting the identifying assumption of parallel trends. Post-treatment coefficients remain close to zero and statistically insignificant through the first year. From approximately the second year onward, point estimates drift modestly upward, but the drift materializes only in the final semesters of the window and the average post-treatment effect remains statistically indistinguishable from zero.

On one hand, PSPO implementation may increase reported anti-social behavior by raising residents' propensity to report ASB to the police; indeed, as the set of formally prohibited behaviors expands, individuals may become more likely to report incidents they previously tolerated. On the other hand, genuine deterrence may operate through potential offenders internalizing the prohibitions of the Order and adjusting their behavior accordingly. If both mechanisms are simultaneously at work, they would offset each other, producing a precisely estimated zero rather than an absence of any effect.¹⁶ The upward pattern of post-

¹⁵We treat adoption as absorbing: only two PSPOs were not renewed after their initial three-year term, and as a conservative choice we drop the LSOAs covered by these Orders.

¹⁶We present suggestive evidence against both mechanisms below and in Section 6.2, though we interpret it cautiously. First, we report immediately below that crimes likely detected exclusively by police officers also show no significant change following PSPO adoption, suggesting the null result is not driven by a reporting offset. Second, evidence presented in Section 6.2 shows that the pretextual enforcement we document may suppress reporting through a different route. Communities exposed to sustained unproductive stop-and-search activity over multiple semesters may become less willing to initiate contact with police, including to report anti-social behavior (Tarling and Morris, 2010; Kirk and Papachristos, 2011; Desmond, Papachristos and Kirk, 2016), which would work against any deterrence effect becoming visible in the data.

treatment coefficients suggests that deterrence is unlikely to be driving the null effect, and that the true underlying incidence of anti-social behavior is unlikely to be falling. Our null result is therefore a lower bound on the ineffectiveness of PSPOs: if the increased propensity to report is generating modest upward pressure on observed counts, correcting for it would push the estimates closer to zero, reinforcing rather than undermining the conclusion that PSPOs had no meaningful deterrent effect.

This conclusion is further corroborated by the absence of any effect on officer-detected crimes. Column (2) of Table 2 reports the effect of PSPOs on officer-detected crimes.¹⁷ Under Section 1 of PACE 1984, officers must hold reasonable grounds for suspecting an individual of carrying weapons, controlled drugs, or articles for use in crime before initiating a search. Under Section 60 of the Criminal Justice and Public Order Act 1994, a senior officer may authorize suspicion-free searches within a designated area in anticipation of violence or disorder. If PSPO-induced searches were grounded in legitimate suspicion under either framework, uncovering contraband or disorder should generate a corresponding rise in recorded ODCs.¹⁸¹⁹ Instead, the estimate is small and insignificant. The corresponding event study, reported in Figure B1 in Appendix A, shows a flat pre-treatment path and post-treatment coefficients centered on zero throughout.

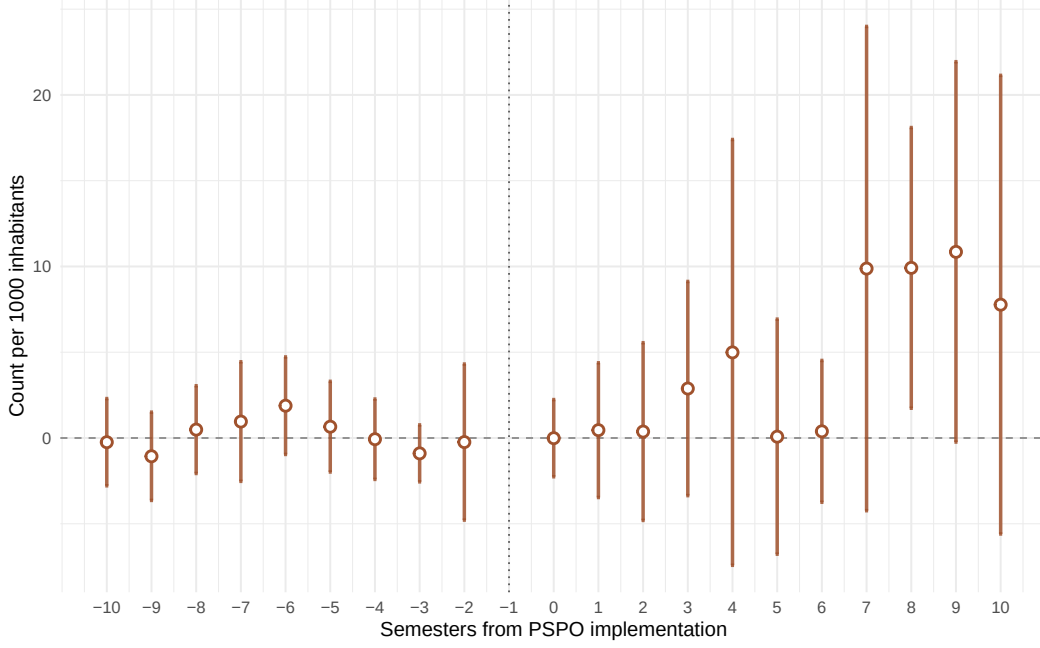
A natural question is whether the ASB null reflects a genuine absence of any effect or, instead, a displacement of anti-social behavior into adjacent untreated areas. To test for this, we run three exercises, reported in Figure B3 panel (a). First, we augment the baseline specification with a time-varying indicator for untreated blocks adjacent to an active PSPO. Second, we drop these spillover-exposed blocks from the control group. Third, we re-estimate the event study treating the neighbors of newly designated PSPOs as the treated units. Anti-social behavior neither falls in treated areas nor rises in their neighbors, which rules out displacement as an explanation for the main null result and reinforces its interpretation as a genuine absence of deterrence.

¹⁷These offenses are usually recorded on the basis of officer-initiated contact rather than victim reports (Home Office, 2026).

¹⁸Under the Home Office Counting Rules, officer-detected crimes must be recorded within 72 hours of coming to the attention of the officer (Home Office, 2026). Given that our outcome variable is aggregated at the semester level, any recording lag is negligible and cannot account for the absence of an effect on ODCs.

¹⁹This result is also free from the concern that residents are more likely to report incidents.

FIGURE 2: EFFECT OF PSPO ON ANTI-SOCIAL BEHAVIOR REPORTS PER 1000 INHABITANTS



Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO on the total number of anti-social behavior crimes per 1,000 inhabitants. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

TABLE 2: EFFECT OF PSPOs ON ANTI-SOCIAL BEHAVIOR AND OFFICER-DETECTED CRIMES

	ASB (1)	Officer-detected crime (2)
PSPO	4.741 (3.700)	-0.447 (2.993)
Mean dep. var.	12.949	5.024
Observations	44,679	44,679

Notes: The table reports the effect of PSPO adoption on recorded crimes per 1,000 residents. In column (1) the outcome measures the total number of anti-social behavior crimes. In column (2) the outcome measure officer-detected crimes (drugs, weapons, and public order). The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, semester, and borough-by-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level and reported in parentheses. The asterisks denote significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

6.2 Unintended Effects: Police Discretion

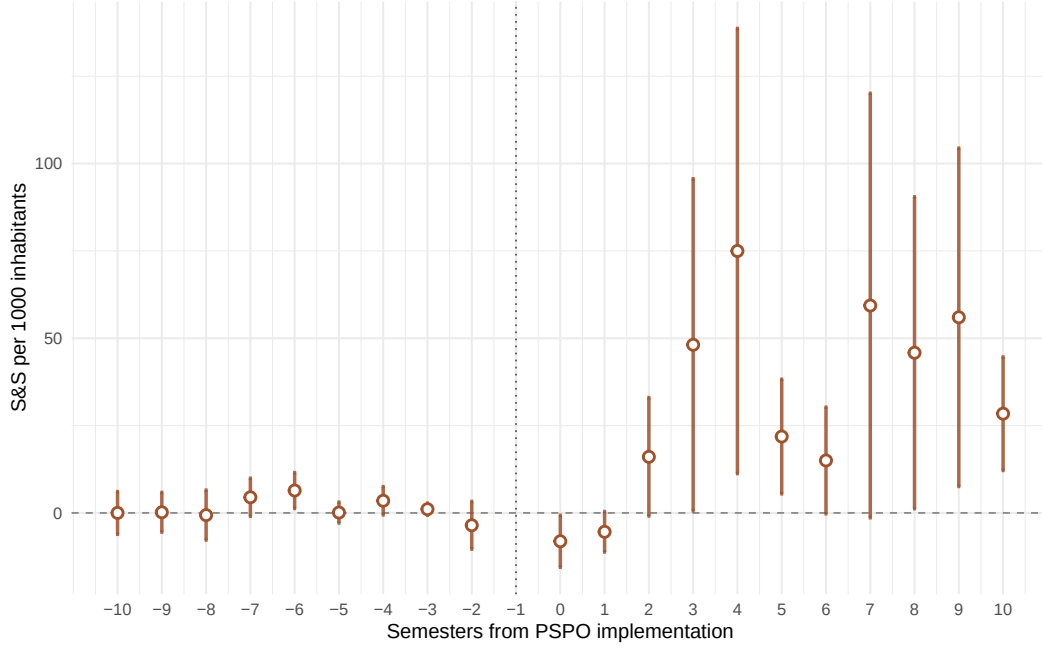
We then turn to the unintended consequences of PSPOs on officers' behavior, focusing on searching powers. As detailed in Section 2.2, PSPOs do not grant officers new stop-and-search powers and do not mandate additional patrol resources.²⁰ Therefore, any change in enforcement activity in treated areas therefore reflects discretionary officer behavior rather than a legal or resource-related response. We find robust evidence that PSPOs substantially increased stop-and-search activity. Table 3 shows that the implementation of PSPOs leads to 28.213 additional searches per 1,000 inhabitants per semester. Relative to a treated pre-treatment mean of 6.4 searches per 1,000 inhabitants, this represents more than a fourfold increase in stop-and-search activity. The event study in Figure 3 shows that pre-treatment coefficients are flat and centered on zero, and that the post-treatment increase emerges gradually, turning consistently positive from the second year of implementation and growing through the post-treatment window. This delayed onset is inconsistent with a mechanical change in officer behavior at the moment of designation; instead, it suggests a progressive adaptation of enforcement practices as officers and BCU commanders become familiar with the new order in place.

As discussed in Section 3, PSPOs may lower the suspicion threshold required to initiate a search, with ambiguous implications for search productivity: a lower threshold could either improve enforcement efficiency by exposing genuinely suspicious individuals to greater scrutiny, or expand officer discretion in ways that generate unproductive searches. To assess which channel dominates, we decompose total searches by their recorded outcome. Under productive policing, we would expect searches ending in further action to rise alongside the total; under expanded discretion and pretextual policing, the rise would instead be concentrated in searches ending with no further action. Table 3 shows that both margins increase, but the expansion is overwhelmingly unproductive: unproductive searches account for 83% of the total increase. The dynamics in Figure 4, which expresses each series in units of its own pre-treatment standard deviation, reinforce this reading: both series are flat before treatment and rise from the second year onward, but the unproductive series climbs roughly twice as far as the productive one and mirrors the overall search response, while productive searches rise later and far more modestly.

To see where the productive searches land, we further split them by the severity of their outcome (Figure 5 and columns (4)–(5) of Table 3). Both tiers increase, but the productive rise is dominated by low-level out-of-court disposals rather than by criminal-justice entry through arrest or court action. Thus, even where searches are “productive,” they overwhelmingly resolve without formal criminal-justice consequences. The decomposition therefore points to expanded discretion and low-yield, pretextual searching rather than a sharpening of productive enforcement.

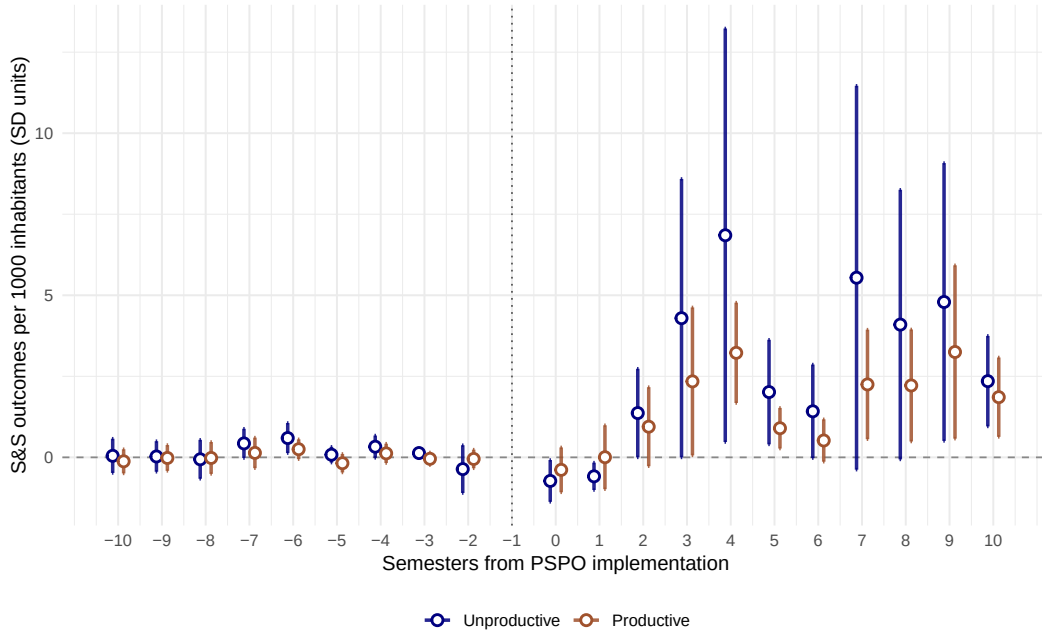
²⁰We test whether changes in police deployment confound our effect in Figure B4.

FIGURE 3: EFFECT OF PSPO ON STOP AND SEARCH PER 1000 INHABITANTS



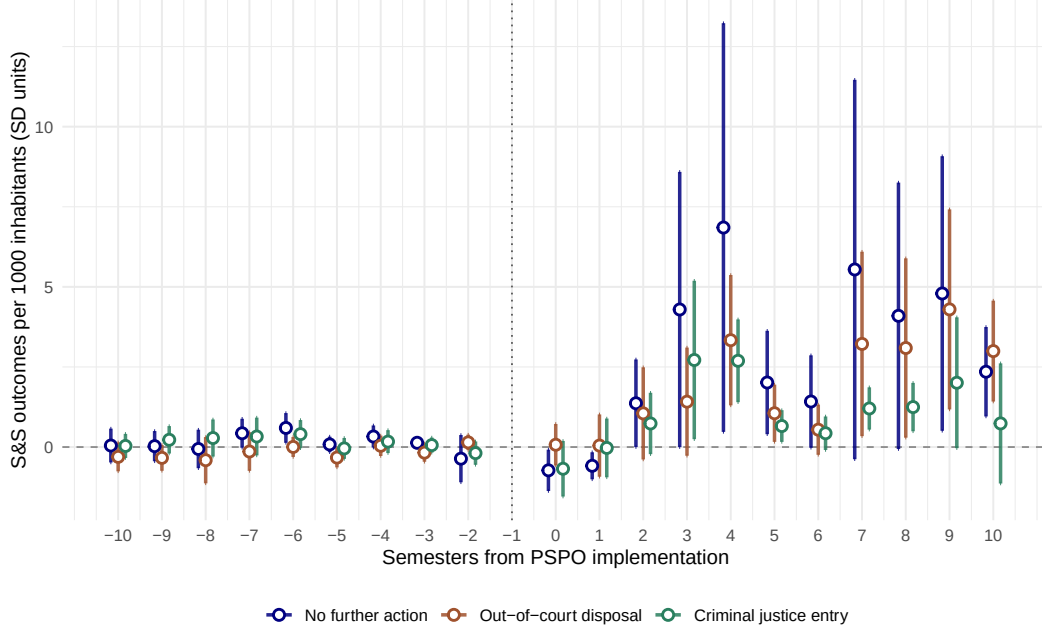
Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO on total number of stop and search per 1,000 inhabitants. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

FIGURE 4: EFFECT OF PSPO ON STOP AND SEARCH BY PRODUCTIVITY OF OUTCOME



Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO on stop and search, decomposed into productive searches (ending in arrest, court action, warnings, or local resolution) and unproductive searches (no further action). All outcomes are presented using standardized units. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

FIGURE 5: EFFECT OF PSPO ON STOP AND SEARCH BY SEVERITY OF OUTCOME



Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO on stop and search, decomposed into three severity tiers: no further action, out-of-court disposal (informal community/local resolution and formal cautions or penalty notices), and criminal justice entry (arrest or court action). All outcomes are presented using standardized units. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

TABLE 3: EFFECT OF PSPOs ON STOP-AND-SEARCH BY OUTCOME

	S&S	Search outcomes		Severity of outcome	
	(1)	Unproductive (2)	Productive (3)	Out-of-court disposal (4)	Criminal justice entry (5)
PSPO	28.213*** (10.224)	23.313** (9.130)	4.898*** (1.297)	3.024*** (1.055)	1.874*** (0.419)
Mean dep. var.	7.576	5.410	2.165	0.929	1.236
Observations	44,679	44,679	44,679	44,679	44,679

Notes: The table reports the effect of PSPO adoption on stop-and-search per 1,000 residents. Column (1) measures all searches; columns (2)–(3) split searches by outcome and columns (4)–(5) measures searches by severity of outcome. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, semester, and borough-by-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level and reported in parentheses. The asterisks denote significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

We next ask whether the expansion of police discretion documented above falls differentially on non-white residents.²¹ In Table 4, the PSPO row reports the effect for white residents and the $\text{PSPO} \times \text{Non-white}$ row the differential for non-white relative to white residents. Column (1) shows that total search rates rise for white residents, while the non-white differential is negative: non-white search rates rise by less than white rates. The same pattern holds across most outcomes: searches conducted under grounds that legally require individualized suspicion, and both unproductive and productive searches, all rise by less for non-white than for white residents. The one exception is searches requiring no suspicion at all, where the differential is

²¹We use the Extended Two-Way Fixed Effects (ETWFE) model proposed by [Wooldridge \(2021\)](#), which allows the treatment effect to vary by covariates through an interaction term.

positive (column 3). Thus, where the law obliges officers to articulate grounds, the PSPO-induced expansion is not differentially borne by non-white residents; where the law requires no grounds at all, it is borne by them almost entirely. This is consistent with PSPOs expanding police discretion specifically at the margin where the legal threshold for a stop is lowest (Knowles, Persico and Todd, 2001a; Anwar and Fang, 2006).

TABLE 4: STOP-AND-SEARCH BY ETHNICITY

	S&S	Grounds for search		Search outcomes		Severity of outcome	
	(1)	Suspicion (2)	No suspicion (3)	Unproductive (4)	Productive (5)	Out-of-court (6)	Criminal justice (7)
PSPO	3.484* (1.923)	3.548* (1.822)	-0.064 (0.137)	2.929** (1.328)	0.557 (0.680)	0.692*** (0.248)	-0.135 (0.603)
PSPO $\times$ Non-white	-1.429*** (0.292)	-1.574*** (0.275)	0.145** (0.065)	-1.138*** (0.231)	-0.292** (0.116)	-0.125* (0.073)	-0.166* (0.087)
Mean dep. var. (white)	5.57	5.50	0.07	3.90	1.67	0.73	0.94
Mean dep. var. (non-white)	8.58	8.36	0.22	5.83	2.75	1.20	1.54
Observations	84,628	84,628	84,628	84,628	84,628	84,628	84,628

Notes: The table reports the effect of PSPO adoption on stop-and-search per 1,000 residents by ethnicity. Column (1) measures the total search rate; columns (2)–(3) split searches by legal grounds, with and without reasonable suspicion, respectively; columns (4)–(5) report search outcomes and columns (6)–(7) reports search outcomes by severity. The model uses the extended two-way fixed-effects estimator proposed by Wooldridge (2021) with LSOA-by-ethnicity and semester fixed effects and borough-specific linear trends. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level and reported in parentheses. The asterisks denote significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

6.3 Effects on Electoral Outcomes

Table 5 reports the effect of PSPO adoption on ward-level council-election outcomes. For each party we report a baseline specification and one that controls for the 2014 UKIP vote share.²² Column (2) shows that PSPO adoption reduces the Conservative vote share by roughly 2.5 percentage points. The event study in Figure B2 panel (a) shows that pre-treatment coefficients are flat for every party except Labour, and that following PSPO implementation the Conservative party experiences a sharp and persistent fall in support.

The remaining columns show where the lost Conservative support goes. Turnout is unchanged (column 9 and Figure B2 panel (b)), so the effect reflects vote switching rather than demobilization. Among the other parties, only UKIP/Reform records a significant gain; the Liberal Democrats show no post-treatment effect, and Labour’s apparent movement fails its pre-trend test and cannot be attributed to PSPO adoption. That the penalty falls specifically on the Conservatives is consistent with their ownership of the policy: PSPOs were created by the Conservative-led government’s Anti-Social Behaviour, Crime and Policing Act 2014 and promoted as a flagship instrument of its law-and-order agenda, and voters in the wards that experience their consequences appear to hold the party most associated with the policy responsible. Consistent with this national-attribution reading rather than local incumbent accountability, the penalty does not vary with the party controlling the adopting council (Table B1): the Conservatives are punished whether or not they run the local authority that implemented the Order.

²²The 2014 local elections coincided with a sharp UKIP surge that fell unevenly across wards; its subsequent collapse mechanically returned votes disproportionately to the Conservatives precisely in the wards that had been most exposed to it. Because treated and control wards differed in their 2014 UKIP vote, this is a common shock with heterogeneous ward-level exposure that additive election-year fixed effects cannot absorb. We therefore assign wards to quartiles of their 2014 UKIP vote share and allow each quartile its own election-year path.

TABLE 5: EFFECT OF PSPOs ON WARD-LEVEL ELECTORAL OUTCOMES

	Conservative		Labour		Lib Dem		UKIP/Reform		Turnout	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
PSPO	-0.059*** (0.018)	-0.025** (0.012)	0.010 (0.017)	0.023 (0.014)	0.007 (0.013)	0.009 (0.010)	0.068** (0.031)	0.013* (0.008)	0.008 (0.010)	0.002 (0.009)
UKIP-2014 $\times$ year	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Ward-elections	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473	3,473
Wards	585	585	585	585	585	585	585	585	585	585

Notes: The table reports the effect of PSPO adoption on ward-level council-election outcomes over the 2002–2022 electoral cycles. For each party, the two columns report a baseline specification and one that additionally adds 2014-UKIP-quartile-by-year effects. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with ward and election-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the borough level and reported in parentheses. The asterisks denote significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

7 Robustness Checks

We assess the sensitivity of our results to a range of alternative specifications and to the main threats to identification. The corresponding event studies and tables are reported in [Appendix A](#). In each case the estimates stay close to the baseline and the substantive conclusions are unaffected.

Spillovers and SUTVA. The primary threat to identification comes from the inclusion of borough $\times$ semester fixed effects in our identification where each treated block is compared to untreated blocks in the same borough and semester, many of them adjacent. Since treatment is highly localised, if officers merely redirect activity across a PSPO boundary then a redistribution of stops could show up as a treatment effect. We run three exercises to alleviate this concern. First, we add a time-varying indicator for untreated blocks adjacent to an active PSPO. Second, we drop these adjacent blocks from the control group. Third, we re-estimate the model treating the neighbours of new PSPOs as the treated units. [Figure B3](#) shows that for the first two exercises the treatment effects stay close to the baseline, and that in the third the spillover-as-treatment estimates sit near zero throughout the post-treatment window. Taken together, these results suggest that the rise in stop-and-search reflects a net increase in enforcement within PSPO zones rather than a redistribution of activity from neighbouring areas.

Police capacity. PSPOs grant no new search powers and mandate no additional patrol resources, but the estimated effect could still be confounded if adoption coincided with austerity-era changes in where the police were physically located. The most relevant change over our period is the wave of Metropolitan Police front-counter closures. To capture a block’s exposure to these closures, we measure how much farther its nearest open front counter lies than its nearest counter that ever operated. A block whose local counter has closed sees this gap widen, whereas a block that never lost a counter has a gap of zero. We then interact this exposure with time and add it to the specification, so that blocks which lost local police infrastructure are free to follow their own trajectory. Adding this control leaves both event studies close to the baseline ([Figure B4](#)), which suggests that differential changes in police deployment do not account for our estimates.

Gentrification. Adoption might also coincide with neighbourhood gentrification, through which rising property values draw police attention and shift demographic composition. To alleviate this concern, we add

a control for the house-pricing. While, housing prices are a strong predictor of stop-and-search activity, figure B5 shows that treatment effects remain close to the baseline over the period. These results suggest that although gentrification is correlated with enforcement, it does not appear to drive the PSPO effect.

Inference and pre-existing orders. Next we test whether our results remain robust to any concerns of anticipation and inference. In Table B2 columns (3) and (6) we re-estimate the model on the subsample of blocks whose PSPO was genuinely new rather than a conversion of a predecessor order.²³ The estimates remain close to the baseline, which suggests that our findings are not driven by anticipation in areas already subject to an order. We further examine the robustness of our results by randomly reshuffling which order clusters are treated, holding fixed the number of treated clusters and their adoption dates, and re-estimate the effect. Table B3 provides the estimates of this exercise. Lastly, in table B2 columns (2) and (5) we cluster standard errors on the connected sets of blocks covered by a common order rather than on individual blocks. Overall, our results remain robust and close to the baseline to various alternative specifications.

8 Conclusion

This paper provides causal evidence on the consequences of expanding police discretionary authority through place-based legislation. Using the staggered rollout of Public Space Protection Orders across London from 2015 to 2024, we trace the effects of a policy designed to reduce anti-social behaviour on three interconnected outcomes: ASBs, police enforcement practices, and community electoral behaviour. Our findings reveal a systematic gap between the stated rationale for these orders and their observed effects.

First, PSPOs do not significantly affect ASBs’ reports. Our preferred estimates, drawn from the interaction-weighted estimator of Sun and Abraham (2021) with demanding within-borough fixed effects, show no meaningful effect of PSPO introduction on recorded anti-social behaviour, either coming from a deterrence or a displacement effect. The null result for anti-social behaviour is robust to reclassification checks and alternative treatment definitions. Post-treatment event-study coefficients remain close to zero throughout the entire post-treatment window, providing no evidence of a deterrent effect at any horizon. If anything, the reporting-propensity concern operates in a conservative direction: communities subjected to repeated unproductive enforcement encounters may become progressively less willing to contact police, biasing recorded ASB estimates downward relative to true incidence and making PSPOs appear more effective than they are. The flat event-study profile therefore reinforces, rather than undermines, our conclusion of no meaningful deterrent effect on disorder.

We investigate the unintended consequences of the policy, and we find that PSPOs generate a large and persistent increase in discretionary stop-and-search activity. Treated areas experience approximately a doubling of search rates relative to control areas, with the effect accumulating gradually over the first year of

²³The baseline specification already excludes units whose PSPO was an exact conversion of a predecessor order, but it retains units whose PSPO extended a predecessor order by adding further orders.

implementation and scaling with the geographic intensity of PSPO coverage. This pattern suggests that officers progressively incorporate spatial designations into their enforcement routine as familiarity with the Order grows and BCU commanders begin directing resources accordingly. The composition of these searches reveals whether the rise in activity reflects genuinely productive targeting or a broader and less discriminate exercise of officer discretion. The entire increase is accounted for by stops ending with no further action; productive searches, resulting in arrest, warnings, show no discernible change, while officer-detected crimes remain uniformly null across all specifications. This joint pattern is consistent with pretextual policing: PSPO designations function as a contextual opportunity for discretionary stops not grounded in specific suspicion and yielding no enforcement benefit. Furthermore, our triple-difference estimates show that the stop-and-searches increase falls almost entirely on non-white residents, generating a differential of approximately 12% in the non-white search rate relative to the white search rate that is remarkably stable across all specifications. This pattern is consistent with minority status serving as a proxy for suspicion when the *de facto* cost of initiating a stop is lowered by policy design (Knowles, Persico and Todd, 2001b; Livingston, 1997), and with a broader literature showing that vaguely defined institutional mandates create structural conditions for discriminatory enforcement (Livingston, 1997; Archer, 2023).

Last, we provide preliminary evidence suggesting that these policing patterns might carry political costs. Treated electoral wards experience a shift away from the parties that formulated the policy. These results contribute to a growing literature on the political consequences of policing (Weaver and Lerman, 2010; Tyler, Fagan and Geller, 2014; Morris and Shoub, 2024) by showing that the political costs of police authority can accumulate through the everyday exercise of discretionary power, without requiring highly visible incidents of force.

Taken together, our results suggest that PSPOs expanded the contextual grounds for discretionary enforcement without reducing the behaviour they were designed to target, concentrated that enforcement on non-white residents in a manner consistent with statistical discrimination, and generated measurable electoral backlash. The entire mechanism operates through officer discretion rather than any formal expansion of legal powers: PSPOs do not amend PACE 1984, do not mandate additional patrol resources, and carry no prescribed enforcement protocol.

The findings carry important policy implications. The Anti-Social Behaviour, Crime and Policing Act 2014 grants local councils the authority to define prohibited behaviours in broad and often vague terms and designate enforcement areas without judicial oversight. Our findings suggest that this design generates unproductive enforcement activity, racially concentrated targeting, and political disaffection among affected communities. The absence of any effect on reported anti-social behaviour calls into question whether PSPOs achieve their stated objective. The enforcement patterns they enable, which are concentrated on non-white residents and predominantly unproductive, are instead more likely to erode the community relations and institutional trust on which effective policing depends. The evidence presented here suggests that the social costs, borne disproportionately by non-white communities and detectable even in electoral outcomes, may

substantially outweigh the public order benefits that justify the policy's adoption.

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SUPPLEMENTARY APPENDICES

Appendix A: Anecdotal Evidence and Descriptive Statistics

FIGURE A1: EXAMPLE OF PUBLIC SPACES PROTECTION ORDER (PSPO) IN THE LONDON BOROUGH OF BARKING AND DAGENHAM

Barking and Dagenham Council
Anti-social Behaviour, Crime and Policing Act 2014
BARKING AND DAGENHAM COUNCIL,
PUBLIC SPACES PROTECTION ORDER

Barking and Dagenham Council (herein "the Council") makes this Order under section 59 of the Anti-Social Behaviour, Crime and Policing Act 2014 ("the 2014 Act"), having consulted as required by section 72.

The order takes effect on 12 March 2021 for the period of 36 months.

It applies to the public place: As marked in red on the attached map. This will be known as "The Restricted Area".

The Council is satisfied that activities have been carried out in this Restricted Area which have had a detrimental effect on the quality of life of those in the locality. Further, it is satisfied that the effect of these activities is or is likely to be of a persistent or continuing nature and is or is likely to be such as to make the activities unreasonable and the effect justifies the restrictions imposed.

The activities carried out are as follows:

1. Consumption of alcohol in a public place
2. Public urination
3. Spitting
4. Beggings
5. Groups engaging in behaviour which causes residents and other users of the area nuisance, annoyance, harassment, alarm and distress.

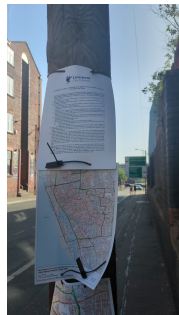
(A) EXTRACT OF THE ORDER

THE RESTRICTED AREA



(B) ATTACHED MAP

FIGURE A2: EXAMPLES OF PSPOs ACROSS THE UK



(A) LIVERPOOL



(B) KENT



(C) WAKEFIELD

FIGURE A3: LSOA BOUNDARIES AND CENTROIDS, AND PSPO COVORAGE ACROSS THE ENTIRE PERIOD.

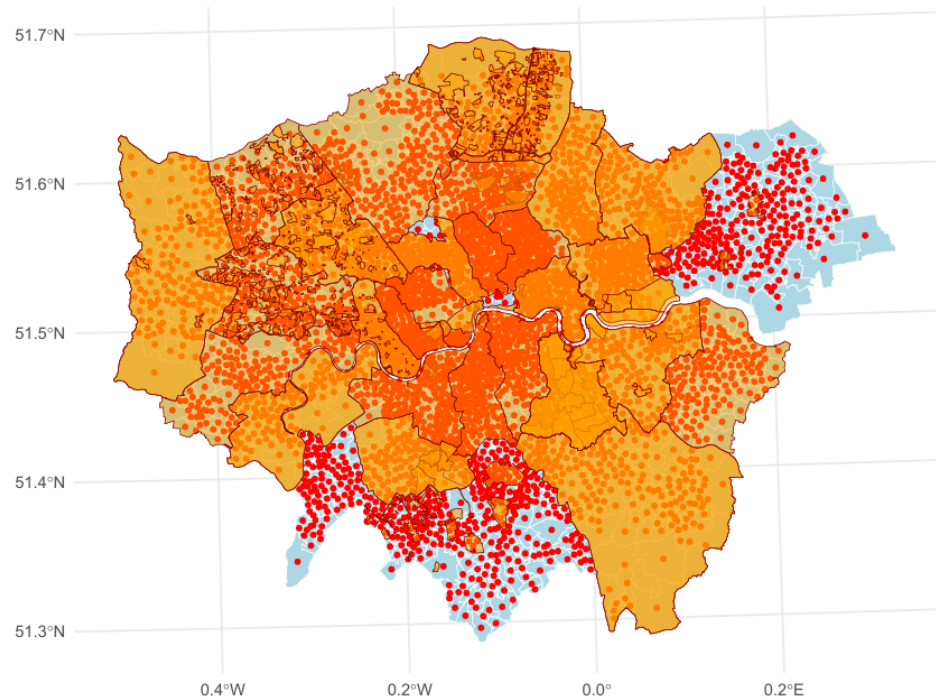


FIGURE A4: PSPOs BY THE TYPE OF ASB TARGETED

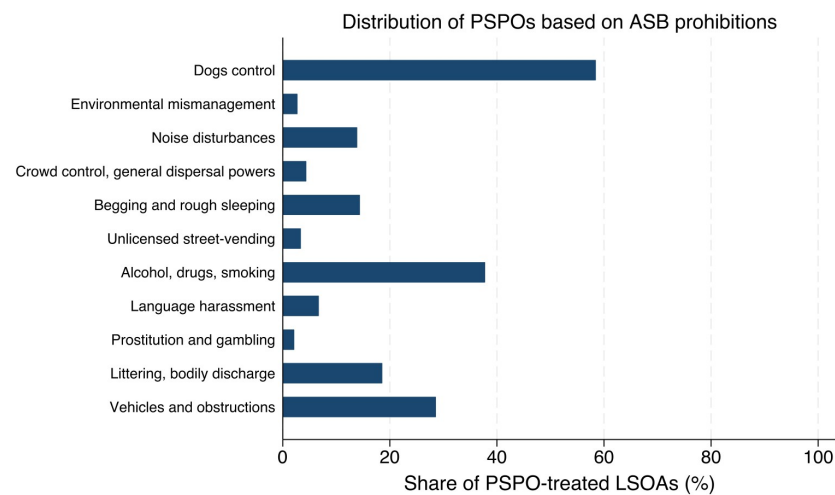
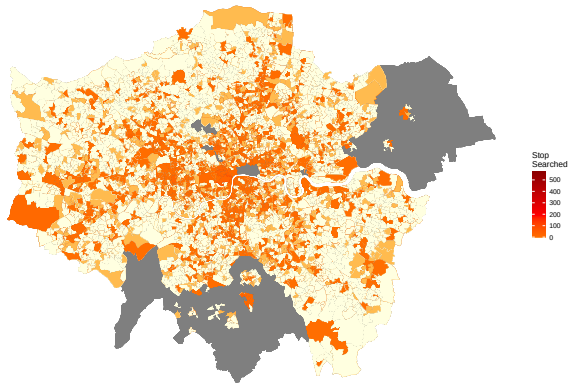


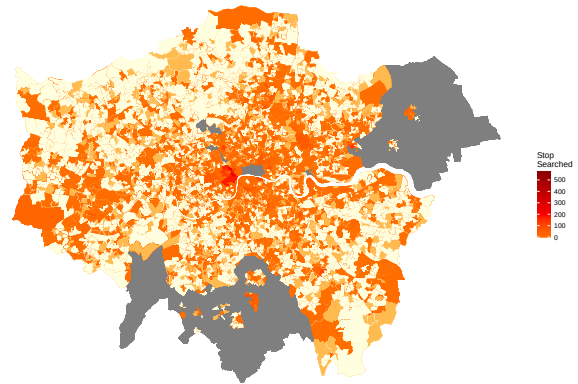
FIGURE A5: STOP AND SEARCH CONCENTRATION IN TREATED AND NEVER TREATED CENSUS BLOCKS ACROSS TIME

Stop and Search by LSOA – 2016 [PSPO == 1 coloured]
Number of persons stop-searched. Non-target LSOAs shown in gray.



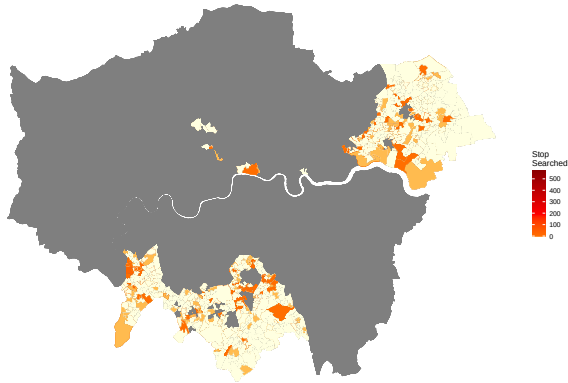
(A) STOP AND SEARCH IN TREATED BLOCKS, 2016

Stop and Search by LSOA – 2019 [PSPO == 1 coloured]
Number of persons stop-searched. Non-target LSOAs shown in gray.



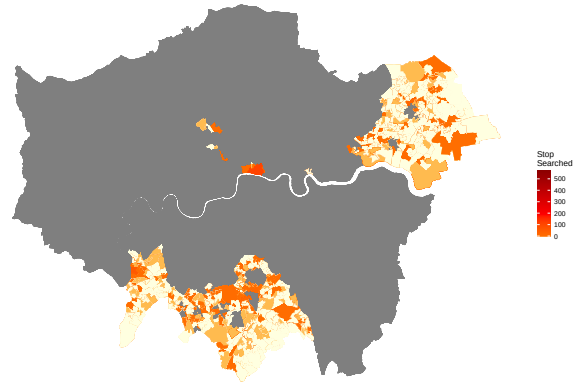
(B) STOP AND SEARCH IN TREATED BLOCKS, 2019

Stop and Search by LSOA – 2016 [PSPO == 0 coloured]
Number of persons stop-searched. Non-target LSOAs shown in gray.



(C) STOP AND SEARCH IN NEVER TREATED BLOCKS, 2016

Stop and Search by LSOA – 2019 [PSPO == 0 coloured]
Number of persons stop-searched. Non-target LSOAs shown in gray.



(D) STOP AND SEARCH IN NEVER TREATED BLOCKS, 2019

FIGURE A6: S&S OUTCOMES BY YEAR

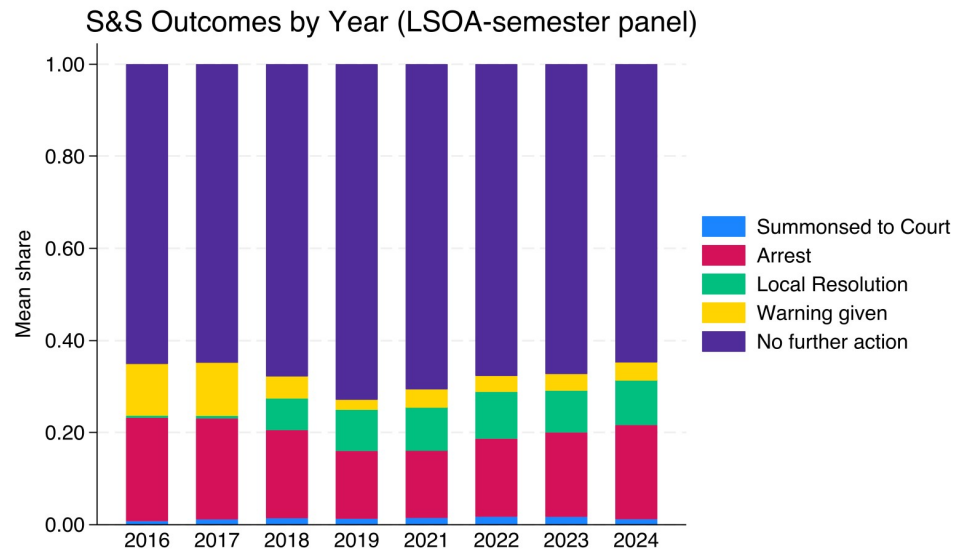


FIGURE A7: ELECTORAL OUTCOMES BY YEAR

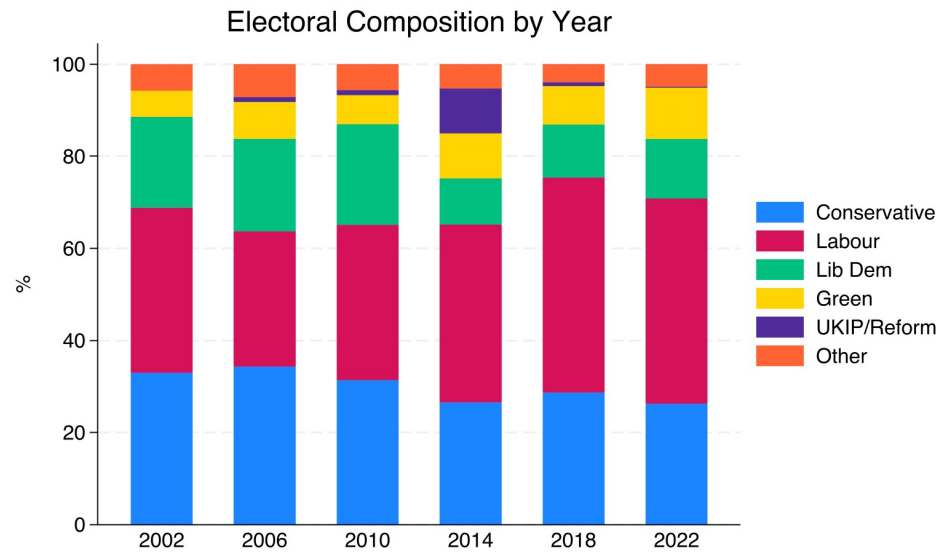


FIGURE A8: POLICE STATIONS, PCSOs, PSPOs AREAS

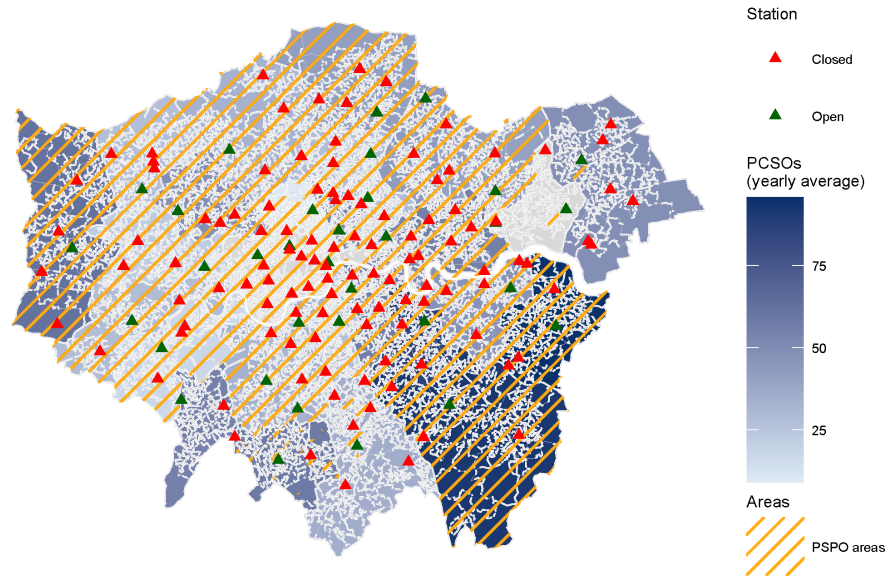
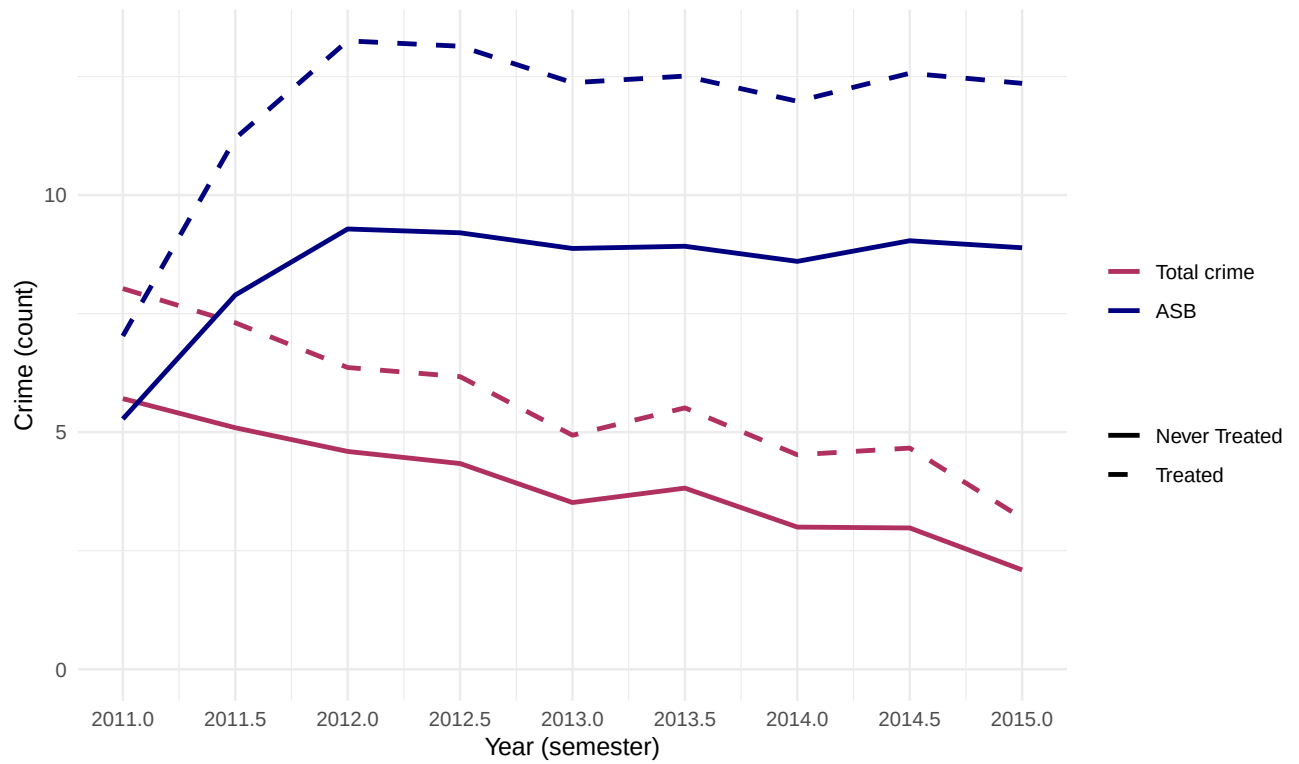
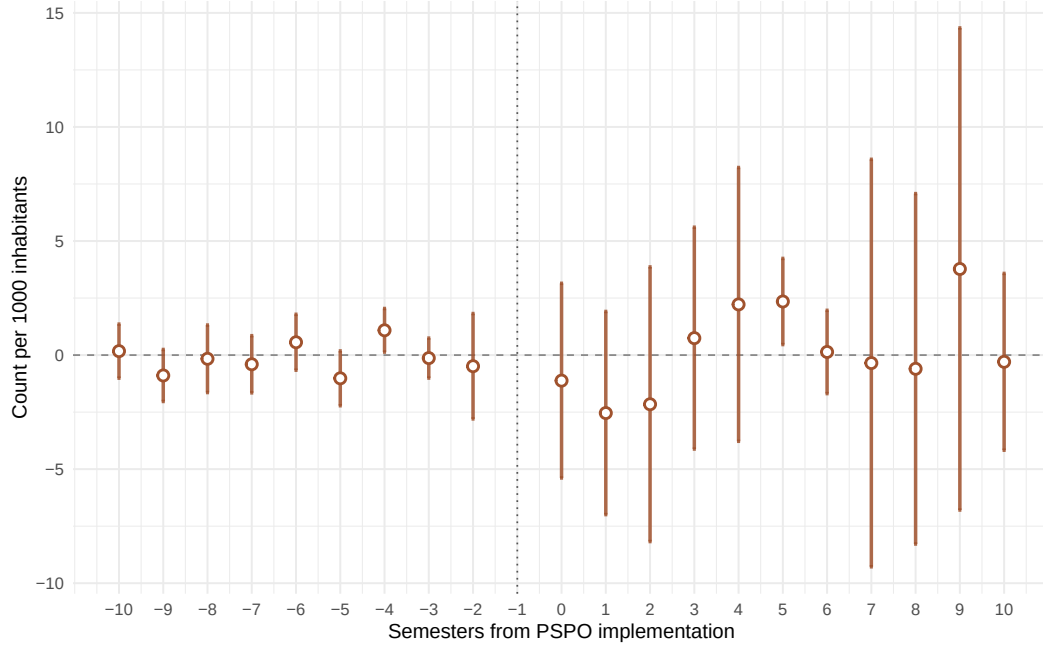


FIGURE A9: TRENDS IN THE TOTAL NUMBER OF CRIMES AND ANTI-SOCIAL BEHAVIOUR FOR TREATED AND NEVER TREATED CENSUS BLOCKS BEFORE THE INTRODUCTION OF PSPOs.



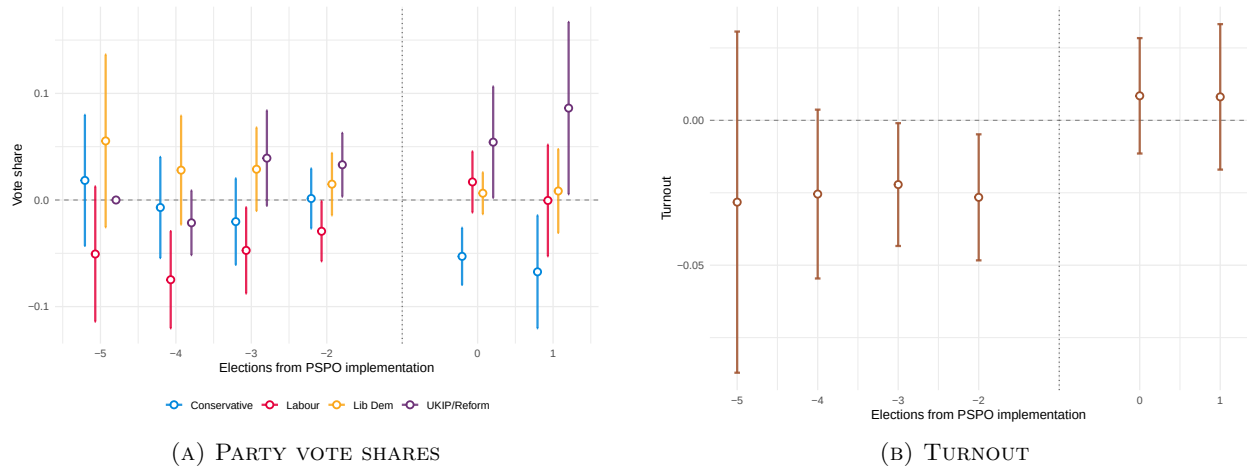
Appendix B: Robustness Checks

FIGURE B1: DYNAMIC EFFECT OF PSPO ON OFFICER-DETECTED CRIMES PER 1000 INHABITANTS



Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO on officer-detected crimes (the combined count of drug, weapons, and public order offences) per 1,000 inhabitants. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

FIGURE B2: EVENT STUDIES: ELECTORAL OUTCOMES



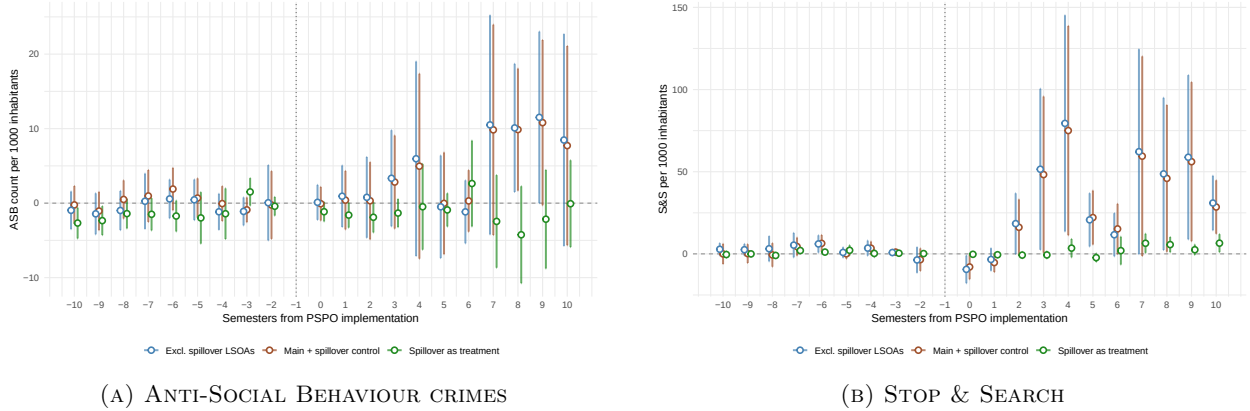
Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPOs on electoral outcomes at the ward level. Panel (a) reports vote shares for the Conservative, Labour, Liberal Democrat and UKIP/Reform families; panel (b) reports turnout. The horizontal axis denotes time relative to PSPO implementation. Estimates come from the baseline specification: an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with ward and election-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the borough level and bars denote 95% confidence intervals.

TABLE B1: VOTE-SHARE PENALTY BY ADOPTING-COUNCIL PARTY

	Labour Adopted		Conservative Adopted	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Conservative	-0.064*** (0.016)	-0.023** (0.011)	-0.047 (0.041)	-0.031 (0.026)
UKIP-2014 $\times$ year	No	Yes	No	Yes
Treated wards	334	334	141	141

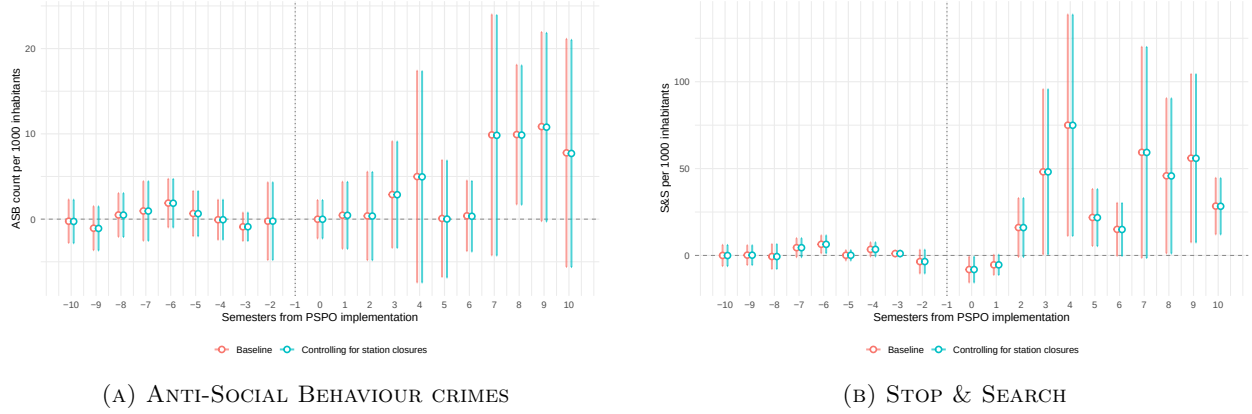
Notes: The table reports the effect of PSPO adoption on the party vote share, allowing the effect to differ by the party controlling the council that implemented the order. “Labour-adopted” and “Conservative-adopted” report the penalty depending on the party that adopted PSPO. Column (1)-(3) is the baseline specification; column (2)-(4) adds 2014-UKIP-quartile-by-year effects. The model uses the interaction-weighted estimator of [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with ward and election-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the borough level and reported in parentheses. The asterisks denote significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

FIGURE B3: CONTROLS FOR SPILLOVERS



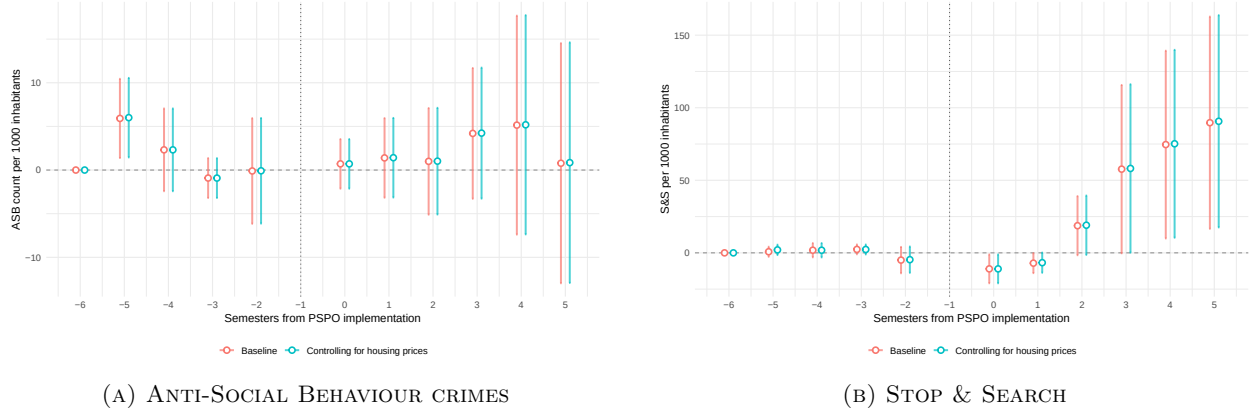
Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO controlling for spillovers. In panel A, the outcome measures total number of anti-social behaviour crimes per 1,000 inhabitants. In column B, the the outcome measures the total number of stop and search per 1,000 inhabitants. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

FIGURE B4: CONTROLLING FOR POLICE CAPACITY



Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO controlling for police capacity. In panel A, the outcome measures total number of anti-social behaviour crimes per 1,000 inhabitants. In column B, the the outcome measures the total number of stop and search per 1,000 inhabitants. The horizontal axis denotes time the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

FIGURE B5: CONTROLS FOR HOUSING PRICING INDEX



Notes: The figure reports the dynamic effect of the introduction of PSPO controlling for housing prices index. In panel A, the outcome measures total number of anti-social behaviour crimes per 1,000 inhabitants. In column B, the the outcome measures the total number of stop and search per 1,000 inhabitants. The horizontal axis denotes the event window restricted to $[-10, +10]$ semesters relative to PSPO implementation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, year-semester, and borough $\times$ year-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the LSOA level.

TABLE B2: ROBUSTNESS: INFERENCE AND PRE-EXISTING ORDERS

	ASB			Stop & Search		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
PSPO	4.741 (3.700)	4.741 (5.327)	3.709 (2.496)	28.213*** (10.224)	28.213*** (6.179)	23.810*** (8.625)
Mean dep. var.	12.949	12.949	12.894	7.576	7.576	7.471
Observations	44,679	44,679	25,523	44,679	44,679	25,523
Clustering	LSOA	PSPO order	LSOA	LSOA	PSPO order	LSOA
Sample	Full	Full	Excl. pre-existing	Full	Full	Excl. pre-existing

Notes: The table estimates the effect of PSPO adoption on anti-social behaviour (columns 1–3) and stop-and-search (columns 4–6) per 1,000 residents under alternative inference and samples. Columns (1) and (4) reproduce the baseline; columns (2) and (5) cluster standard errors on PSPO orders rather than on LSOAs; columns (3) and (6) exclude LSOAs subject to a predecessor order before PSPO designation. The model uses an interaction-weighted estimator proposed by [Sun and Abraham \(2021\)](#) with LSOA, semester, and borough-by-semester fixed effects. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. The asterisks denote significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

TABLE B3: RANDOMISATION INFERENCE

	Anti-social Behaviour (1)	Stop & Search (2)
PSPO	4.741	28.213
Placebo mean	0.209	−0.475
RI p -value	0.035	0.000
Permutations	200	200

Notes: The table reports randomisation-inference tests of the effect of PSPO adoption on anti-social behaviour and stop-and-search per 1,000 residents. In each of 200 permutations we randomly reassign PSPO treatment across the order clusters, holding fixed the observed distribution of adoption dates, and re-estimate the interaction-weighted ATT. Placebo mean is the average placebo estimate; the RI p -value is the share of placebo estimates at least as large in absolute value as the actual estimate.